A job done

After spending a night in Toronto, I reached New York on the morning of 25 September and checked into a hotel close to the upscale and well-equipped Hotel Helmsley Place on Madison Avenue where the prime minister and her delegation would be staying. After spending four days (20–24 September) on her state visits to Cyprus and Greece and making a brief stopover at Paris on 25 September, Indira Gandhi and her delegation reached JFK airport late in the evening on 26 September.

Compared with her state visit of the previous year, the reception at the airport was a low-key affair. Only two Indian press reporters, including G.S. Chawla of the *Indian Express* , had accompanied her on the flight. Against a full complement of three senior IB officers in charge of her security the previous year, only one officer was in attendance this time – Ratan Sahgal, with his supporting staff. There was hardly any press coverage of her arrival or her activities during her entire stay in New York. Even her speech at the UNGA was not covered by the local press.

Sometime after her arrival at the hotel, I got a copy of her New York itinerary. In addition to her speech at the UNGA on 28 September, she was to meet US President Ronald Reagan and chair two informal get-togethers of twenty-four leaders from Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) countries on 27 and 29 September. There were some press interviews as well. This time she made it a point to address US-based members of the Indian press, whom she could not meet as a group during her previous visit. Also, there were the usual rounds of discussions with editors, dinners with a few groups and friends, addresses to prominent persons from the local Indian community, inauguration of a photo exhibition on Jawaharlal Nehru, visits to some shows, and shopping. [1]

On the morning of 27 September I visited the consul general of India’s (CGI) office in New York to see if I could meet someone known to me there. On arrival, I saw that they had set up a control room there in connection with the prime minister’s visit. In addition to meeting Indian high commissioner to Canada Sivarama Krishnan who had also reached New York, I also ran into K.C. Singh (IFS